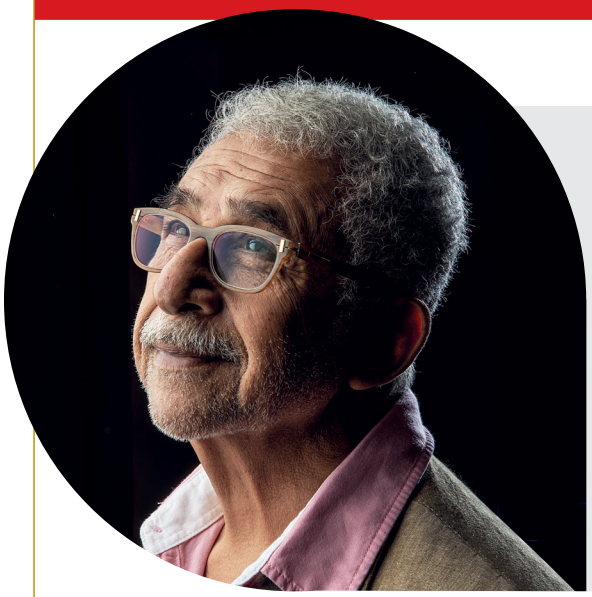


BANDEEP SINGH

Naseeruddin Shah

Versatile, intelligent, the anchoring in theatre bringing a laser-focus on his craft, Naseer came at just the right time to be the perfect man for the "parallel" films of Shyam Benegal, Saeed Mirza, Govind Nihalani, Ketan Mehta and others. With recent print restorations, we have been able to rediscover some of his outstanding, less-seen work, such as the narcissistic Raja in *Bhavni Bhavai* (1980). Despite his disdain for the mainstream, he had an amusing if uneven career there, having a rollicking good time in films like *Jalwa* (1987), *Tridev* (1989) and *Krrish* (2006).



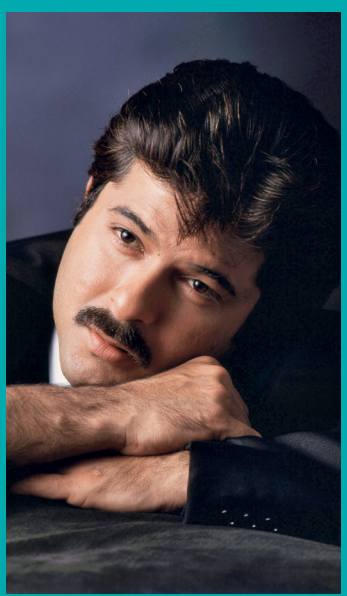
INDIA PICTURE

Irrfan Khan

The "what could have been" question will always haunt our thoughts of Irrfan—who departed much too young in 2020—but the consolation will have to be that the "what is" still burns like a spectacular fire. Throughout his career, Irrfan kept raising the bar for powerful, internalised acting, from his best homegrown roles (*Maqbool*, 2004; *The Namesake*, 2006; *Paan Singh Tomar*, 2012; *The Lunchbox*, 2013) to international productions like *Life of Pi* (2012). But he also showed an ability to throw himself wholeheartedly into massy escapism—watch the otherwise dull *Jazbaa* (2015) for his marvellous wisecracking-action-hero turn.

Anil Kapoor

One of those so easy to take for granted, though there has been appreciation of late for his fitness well into his 60s! But think about it and you'll realise how much he has meant to two or more generations of viewers, and what a range of iconic or loved films he has enlivened: from '80s outings (Chameli ki Shaadi, Mr India, Tezaab) all the way to his comic turn in No Entry *(2005), the rakish patriarch in Dil Dhadakne Do (2015), the self-lacerating AK vs AK (2020).*



INDIA PICTURE



Manoj Bajpayee

Versatility is a quality often over-emphasised, but it can be breathtaking when an actor truly pulls it off. Look no further than Bajpayee's brawny, profane Sardar Khan in *Gangs of Wasseypur* (2012) being followed by his reticent, soft-spoken characters in *Aligarh* (2015) and *Bhonsle* (2018, barely speaking here). After his defining early work (*Satya*, 1998; *Kaun?*, 1999), he was out in the wilderness for a while but recovered to make a strong comeback in both films and in web series (*The Family Man*, 2019–). Many career highlights perchance lie ahead.